

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

<think>

Finding Reasoning Paths :

1 . **Persistent sadness** and difficulty making decisions could indicate a long-term mood disorder , possibly major depressive disorder .

2 . **Worsening suicidal ideations** , **guilt from past problems** , **energy changes** , and **concentration issues** suggest a recent exacerbation of a pre-existing mood disorder , potentially bipolar depression or major depressive disorder with psychotic features .

3 . **Chronic pessimism** and **feeling cursed** might point to a chronic mood disorder rather than a transient episode .

4 . **Sleeping well** and ability to hold a job suggest the patient is functional , which makes severe mania or psychotic episodes less likely in this case .

5 . The combination of **chronic sadness** , **worsening suicidal ideations** , and **recent changes in energy and concentration** could indicate a transition from a chronic condition to an acute exacerbation .

Reasoning Process :

1 . **Initial assessment** : The patient reports persistent sadness and difficulty making decisions , both of which have been present for a long time . These symptoms are characteristic of a chronic mood disorder , such as major depressive disorder (MDD).

2 . **Recent changes** : Over the past two weeks , the patient has experienced worsening suicidal ideations , guilt , energy changes , and concentration problems . These acute symptoms suggest a recent exacerbation of a pre-existing condition .

3 . **Symptom overlap** : The worsening suicidal ideations and guilt could indicate depression , while the energy changes and concentration issues might suggest either depression or mania . However , the presence of sleepiness (indicated by "sinking into his sleep") and functional ability (holding a job) makes significant manic symptoms less likely .

4 . **Chronic pessimism** : The patient's chronic pessimism and feeling of being cursed are consistent with a long-standing mood disorder . However , the recent worsening symptoms suggest a shift in the condition , likely from chronic depression to acute exacerbation of a chronic mood disorder .

5 . **Differentiation from mania or psychosis** : The lack of manic symptoms , such as increased energy , rapid speech , or hallucinations , makes bipolar disorder less likely . Similarly , the absence of severe psychotic symptoms (e.g . , delusions , hallucinations) makes psychotic disorders unlikely .

6 . **Bipolar depression** : The combination of chronic depressive symptoms (sadness , difficulty making decisions) and acute worsening symptoms (suicidal ideations , energy changes , concentration problems) is consistent with bipolar depression . This subtype of bipolar disorder involves periods of depression with elements of acute mood changes .

7 . **Paranoid personality disorder** : While the patient exhibits chronic pessimism , there is no evidence of paranoid ideation or social anxiety . The symptoms do not align with the criteria for paranoid personality disorder .

Conclusion :

The patient is likely to be suffering from **bipolar depression** , a subtype of bipolar disorder with features of a chronic mood disorder and acute exacerbation . The condition involves both persistent depressive symptoms and acute mood changes , such as worsening suicidal ideations and energy changes .

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The patient is likely to show anhedonia .

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